



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Rodents have four special incisor teeth that are used for gnawing; rabbits have eight.
- Furry coats
- Clawed toes

When

They first appeared in the Paleogene Period (about 65 million years ago) and still exist today.

Eomys

EE-oh-miss

- **When** 25 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** France, Germany, Spain, Turkey
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 10 in (25 cm)
- **Diet** Plants

This small rodent could glide through the air. Many *Eomys* skeletons have been found, showing that it had a long skin membrane between its front and back legs, rather like that of a modern

flying squirrel. *Eomys* is thought to be a close relative of gophers and pocket mice that exist today.



Palaeolagus

PAY-lee-oh-LAG-us

- **When** 33–23 million years ago (Late Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Plains and woodlands
- **Length** 4 in (10 cm)
- **Diet** Grass

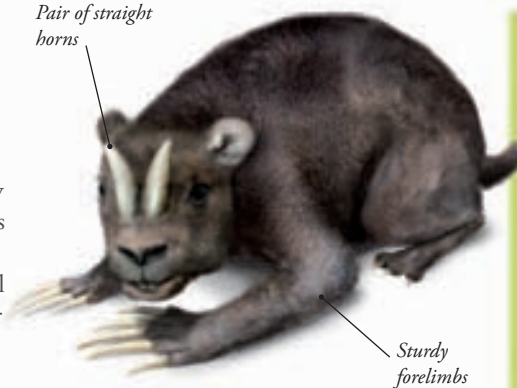
Palaeolagus is one of the oldest known fossil rabbits. It had long, pointed ears and a slightly longer tail than modern animals. Its hindlimbs were shorter than those of living rabbits, which suggests that it scampered like a squirrel rather than hopping. It had two pairs of upper teeth to nibble on grass and other plants.



Ceratogaulus

seh-RAT-oh-GAWL-us

Pair of straight horns



- **When** 10–5 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Canada, USA
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 12 in (30 cm)
- **Diet** Plants

Known as the horned gopher, *Ceratogaulus* is the smallest mammal known to have had horns and one of the only horned rodents. Scientists once thought that it used its horns for digging, but their position on the skull makes this unlikely. Both sexes had horns, so they were probably used for defense rather than mating displays. *Ceratogaulus* lived in burrows that it dug with its large claws. Its eyes were small and its vision was probably poor.

